

Investors in training know to stay away from startup investment brokers that haven't been around very long. Often these brokers try to grow quickly and sell off their company. Their end goal may not always be to keep their customers happy.

5. *Can you have your funds in your name?* Some brokers will put the shares you own under your name, while others will put them under their name for ease of management. You still get to buy, sell and withdraw them regardless, so this isn't important to many investors. However some investors like the ability to have full voting rights on the shares they own, and it's easier to move shares around different brokers if they own them, so it's important to check if this is the case.

Investment company platforms

You can invest in mutual funds directly with the companies that own them. This may save you on fees, and if you are investing with a higher amount (e.g. \$1000 a month) then you don't need to worry about fractional shares and can invest in an index fund directly.

An example of this would be investing through Vanguard's website into their funds. The downside of doing this, however, is that these platforms will push their own products more than any other investment option available, as they have incentive to do so. And some will not offer other investments at all.

Financial planners/advisers

You can invest with a financial adviser. They are professionals who are regulated by their governing bodies to provide you investing advice suited to your needs. This book may not know the ins and outs of your circumstances, your beliefs, values and financial background, but an adviser will be able to guide you through the process.

It is not uncommon for an investor who usually DIYs their portfolio to seek an adviser if they have recently received an inheritance or a large bonus and are unsure how to navigate their money to reach their goals faster.

There are two fee payment mechanisms for financial advice. A fee-based method where you pay a fee and a built-in commission to the investment